canceling-out of the unjustified reputation I have for universal wisdom.

We received a gas bill for $6.50 toward the end of 1946, which was just twice as high as the gas bill anyone else in the apartment building got. We checked that, to make sure, and we were furious.

On December 11, I went to the offices of the gas company in downtown Brooklyn to demand reparation, restitution, and a groveling apology. I waited in line in the greatest indignation and when I finally got to the window, I slapped down the bill and said, angrily, "See here, we have never used enough gas to bring us up to the $2.00 minimum. We have no children. We both work. We cook perhaps four meals a week. How can we possibly get a bill for $6.50? I demand an explanation."

The man behind the counter looked at me mildly. "You really insist on an explanation?"

"Certainly. If you can think of one besides general incompetence."

"Fortunately," he said, "I can think of one. This is an electric bill."

You never saw so quiet and humble a retreat in your life.

*9 Part of my duties as a research student was to prepare a seminar on my research. I had to explain the nature of the problem, then go on to

explain what I was doing and why, what I hoped to accomplish, and so on. When I was done, I was expected to field searching questions from the floor.

Other people in the department were supposed to attend, and the idea was that no one was to become too ingrown, that each student should be exposed to all the other currents permeating the Columbia chemistry department.

That was the theory, but many people found seminars frustrating. Those who lectured on the problem seemed never to grasp the level of ignorance of those not working on it—or were afraid to show anything less than complete erudition. In five minutes, usually, the lecturer had left his audience behind and completed his presentation talking only to himself and his research professor.

I did not intend to do this in my seminar, which was slated for December 17. I lacked intellectual insecurity and I did not feel it necessary to be erudite. Besides, I had my fiction-writing experience, in which one has to assume the